

It's easy to get caught up thinking we would be happy if we just had a little more fame, knowledge, power, prestige, or stuff. Some in the FI community think more money is all we need. Jeff discovered happiness for him can be having less and learning to say no.

Jeff used the analogy of kittens and alligators to describe his approach to decluttering his life in the quest for happiness. Kittens are cute, cuddly, playful creatures that bring happiness while alligators are ugly, menacing, and nasty. If we had a room filled with kittens and alligators and wanted to make it a more peaceful and happy place, we couldn't just add more kittens—they would only provide more food for the gators. It would make for an ugly scene. The obvious place to start would be removing the alligators. However, we rarely recognize this in our daily lives.

Jeff focused on eliminating the things that were detracting from his life rather than trying to add more of the things that we often think will make us happy. He eliminated unnecessary obligations that slipped onto the calendar. He quit watching cable news, which caused anxiety and stress. He resolved to reduce his workload, cutting down to half time, even though it meant taking a financial hit that slowed his time to FI.